



Transforming Nepal's Maize Sector: Innovation, Partnerships, and Investment

*Partners Forum and Field Visit
5-6 June 2026 | Banke, Lumbini, Nepal*



Background

Maize is Nepal's second most important cereal crop after rice, playing a vital role in food security in the hills and serving as an increasingly important industrial crop in the Terai. It supplies raw materials for feed, food, silage, and other agro-industries, creating employment and income opportunities for rural communities.

Despite cultivating maize on approximately 916,000 hectares and producing around 3.19 million tons annually, Nepal continues to import 400,000–500,000 tons of maize each year to meet growing demand. At the same time, large areas of agricultural land remain fallow, particularly in the Terai. With improved irrigation, access to quality inputs, mechanization, technical support, and stronger market systems, these lands could significantly contribute to increasing domestic maize production.

The Maize Commercialization Model (MCM)

To address these challenges and opportunities, CIMMYT, in collaboration with the Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development (MoALD), the Nepal Agricultural Research Council (NARC), private-sector partners, and farmer cooperatives, launched the Maize Commercialization Model (MCM) in 2021 in Nepal's western Terai.



The model promotes market-oriented and sustainable maize production through improved seed and agronomic practices, climate-smart technologies, mechanization, soil fertility management, market linkages, and public-private partnerships.

The initiative began with 872 farmers cultivating 278 hectares in Banke and Bardiya districts. By 2026, it had expanded to approximately 30,000 farmers across 15,000 hectares in nine districts. Maize productivity is projected to increase from 5.5 to 7 tons per hectare, while income generated from previously fallow land is expected to more than triple.

Recognizing its success, the Government of Nepal integrated the MCM approach into its regular agricultural programs in 2025.

Scaling Up for Impact

The Government of Nepal, provincial and local governments, farmer cooperatives, and private-sector partners are now scaling the model across new areas. Through strengthened linkages among research, extension services, and industry, the initiative aims to accelerate technology adoption, increase production, and attract greater public and private investment.

The long-term vision is to expand sustainable maize commercialization to 40,000 hectares by 2030, reducing maize imports, strengthening domestic supply chains, and creating new economic opportunities for farmers and rural communities.

Objectives

The event aims to:

- Showcase innovations and field-level implementation of maize commercialization models in Nepal.
- Demonstrate integrated approaches linking research, extension, mechanization, markets, and private-sector engagement.
- Highlight experiences and lessons from farmers, cooperatives, local governments, and service providers.
- Facilitate dialogue among government, development partners, researchers, and private-sector actors.
- Strengthen understanding of approaches that support resilient and market-oriented maize systems in Nepal.

AGENDA

Day 1: **Friday, 5 June 2026**

Venue: **Hotel Soaltee Westend, Nepalgunj, Banke District, Nepal**

Strategic Briefing and Partner Dialogue

Setting the context for maize systems transformation in Nepal

TIME	SESSION
17:30 - 18:00	Arrival, Registration and Networking Tea
18:00 - 18:30	Chief Guest: Dr. Rajendra Prasad Mishra, Secretary, Ministry of Agriculture, Forests and Environment (MoAFE) Opening Remarks and Introduction • Overview of CIMMYT's program: Dr. Dyutiman Choudhary, Country Representative, CIMMYT • Welcome Remarks: Dr. Tek Prasad Gotame, Director, Crops and Horticulture Research NARC • Remarks: Mr. Shankar Shah, Secretary, Ministry of Land Management, Agriculture and Cooperatives, Sudurpaschim Province.
18:30 - 18:40	Innovation and Partnerships for Resilient and Commercial Maize Systems – Dr. Narayan Khanal, Business Development Manager, CIMMYT
18:40 - 18:50	Government Priorities for Nepal's Maize Sector Transformation – Mr. Keshab Devkota, Chief, Centre for Crop Development and Agro Biodiversity Conservation (CCDABC), Department of Agriculture
18:50 - 19:30	Innovation Marketplace Walk featuring technologies and approaches CIMMYT and NARC
19:30 - 19:40	Launch of the Digital Soil Fertility Report & Recommendations • Introduction by Dr. Dyutiman Choudhary, CIMMYT • Background by Dr. S. P. Vista, Chief, National Soil Science Research Centre, NARC • Launch by Dr. Rajendra Prasad Mishra, Secretary, MoAFE • Walkthrough of the Digital Soil Fertility Report - Satish Nagaraji/Nabaraj Pandit
19:40 - 20:00	• Address by Chief Guest, Dr. Rajendra Prasad Mishra, Secretary, MoAFE • Vote of Thanks - Mr. Tapta Bahadur Poudel, Chairperson, Raptisonari Rural Municipality
20:00 - 22:00	Group Photo & Networking Dinner Reception

AGENDA

Day 2: Saturday, 6 June 2026

Venue: Khajura, and Raptisonari Municipality in Banke, Nepal

Field Immersion and Stakeholder Exchange

Experience maize systems transformation from research to markets

TIME	SESSION
7:00	Travel to Khajura
7:30 - 9:30	Field Visit 1: NARC/CIMMYT Trial and Demonstration Site in Khajura Focus areas: Hybrid maize performance and seed production, good agronomic practices, and soil fertility management • Welcome by Dr. Samid Ahmad, Chief, RARS-Khajura, Banke • Background by Dr. Dyutiman Choudhary, CCR, CIMMYT • Inauguration of Trial and Demonstration Hub Site (NARC Khajura) - Chief Guest, Dr. Rajendra Prasad Mishra, Secretary, MoAFE Remarks by • Chief Guest - Dr. Rajendra Prasad Mishra, Secretary, MoAFE • Site visit in two groups - Guided by CIMMYT and NARC
9:45 - 10:45	Travel to Balarpur, Raptisonari - 8 Visit to CCDABC/CIMMYT Maize Commercial Model sites and interaction with stakeholders
10:45 - 12:30	Track A - 60 mins: Maize Production and Management • Welcome by CIMMYT • Welcome by Mahila Jagaran Cooperative and brief about MCM journey • Welcome and briefing by Agriculture Section Chief of Raptisonari Municipality • Briefing by seed supplier on seed use and demand • Briefing by Mahila Jagaran Cooperative and Raptisonari Municipality on Integrated Soil Fertility Management - palika soil map; soil fertility report cards; display of liquid fertilizer spraying by drone; application of best management practices • Briefing by machinery suppliers • Briefing on irrigation systems by Mahila Jagaran Cooperative and suppliers • Maize post harvest management - drying and shelling by Mahila Jagaran Cooperative • Maize market trends and marketing innovations - Local trader and processor • Trends in local maize use in feed industries - WellHope Feed Industry Track

10:45 - 12:30	B - 40 mins: Market engagement, equipment handover, interactions, and remarks • Signing of purchase agreement between WellHope Feed Industry and Mahila Jagaran Cooperative • Handing over equipment's supported by CCDABC to Mahila Jagaran Cooperative - Chief CCDABC & Under Secretary, MoAFE • Question and Answer Sessions with farmers, market actors and municipalities Remarks: • Mr. Binod Ghimire, AKC Chief, Banke • Mr. Hikmat Shrestha, Director, National Agriculture Modernization Program Closing Remarks: Chairperson of Raptisonari Municipality
12:45 - 13:15	Drive to Soaltee Hotel Westend, Nepalgunj
13:15 - 14:15	Lunch at Hotel Soaltee Westend, Nepalgunj
14:15 - 16:00	Stakeholder Reflection and Dialogue Session • Maize based cropping system optimization in Western Nepal - lessons and opportunities for Research and Development - Rapid fire talks by MoALD, NARC, provincial Government, local Government, private sector and CIMMYT - Moderated by CIMMYT • Program Development on Commercial Maize Production - panel discussion with Mayors, MoALD, Provincial Government, Private sector and Development partners - Moderated by CIMMYT • Reflections from Participants - Moderated by CIMMYT • Views of development partners on Agri-food system priorities • US Embassy, Nepal • Asian Development Bank • World Bank
16:00 - 16:30	Closing Session Remarks – • Chief, Centre for Crop Development and Agro Biodiversity Conservation (CCDABC), • Dr. Tek Prasad Gotame, Crops and Horticulture Research, NARC • Dr. Januka Pandit, Secretary, MoALM, Lumbini Province • Mr. Tej Bahadur Bhat, Mayor, Madhuban, Rural Municipality • Vote of Thanks - CIMMYT
16:45	Departure